The Noble Great Dhāraṇī

Āryamahādhāraṇī · Toh 888 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་པ་གཟུངས་ཆེན་པོ།

The Noble Great Dhāraṇī, known in Sanskrit as the Āryamahādhāraṇī and in Tibetan as Phagpa Zung Chenpo, is a short scripture centered on a protective incantation taught by the Buddha. It opens at Śrāvastī, in Prince Jeta's Grove, where the Blessed One is staying with a great assembly of twelve hundred and fifty monks. The venerable Ānanda, having completed the summer rains retreat in the city of Sāketa and finished making his robes, comes to pay his respects. The Buddha then addresses him, introducing a great dhāraṇī to be taught for the benefit, welfare, and happiness of beings. The work is Toh 888 in the Kangyur, where it belongs to the class of dhāraṇī texts, scriptures that preserve and transmit sacred formulas believed to protect and bring blessings to those who recite and uphold them.

In the language of India: āryamahādhāraṇī. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Great Dhāraṇī.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was staying at Śrāvastī, in Prince Jeta's Grove, the park of Anāthapiṇḍada, together with a great Saṅgha of twelve hundred and fifty monks. At that time the venerable Ānanda had spent the three summer months of the rains retreat in the city of Sāketa, and he made his robes. When the robes were finished, he took up his bowl and robes and set out for the place where the Blessed One was. On arriving, he bowed his head at the Blessed One's feet and sat down to one side. When he had sat down to one side, the Blessed One said this to the venerable Ānanda:

"Ānanda, for the benefit, the welfare, the happiness, the strength and the splendor of all sentient beings, take up these secret mantra bases of the great dhāraṇī! Hold them! Receive them! Learn them! Master them completely! Keep them in mind! And why? Ānanda, the secret mantra bases of the great dhāraṇī are hard to find, and the appearance in the world of the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, is also hard to find, like the udumbara flower. Therefore take them up! Hold them! Receive them! Learn them! Keep them in mind! Master them completely!

"Ānanda, if any faithful son of good family or daughter of good family bears, holds, reads, keeps in mind, or masters these secret mantra bases of the great dhāraṇī, that person will not meet death by weapons, nor by poison, nor by fire, nor by water, nor by the punishment of a king; that person will not die an untimely death. That person cannot be harmed by gods, asuras, nāgas, Vāyu, garuḍas, gandharvas, kinnaras, mahoragas, yakṣas, rākṣasas, pretas, piśācas, kumbhāṇḍas, pūtanas, kaṭapūtanas, bhūtas, apasmāras, unmādas, oppressing spirits, shadow-seizing spirits, slayers, harm-doers, or sorcery. That person cannot be harmed by humans or nonhumans. That person cannot be harmed by rites of spell-craft, by acts of speech, or by acts of mind. That person will not be overcome by one-day fevers, second-day fevers, third-day fevers, fourth-day fevers, chronic fevers, fevers caused by bhūtas, or momentary fevers, nor by illnesses arising from wind, from bile, from phlegm, or from their combination.

"These, then, are the secret mantra bases of the great dhāraṇī:

tadyathā jvale mahājvale jvalane mahājvalane tāpane mahātāpane jvalite ukake bugage saṃbhade mahāsaṃbhade cakre mahācakre Protect me and all sentient beings from all fears, from harm, and from all contagious diseases, protect us, protect us! svāhā

"Ānanda, these secret mantra bases of the great dhāraṇī were spoken by seven hundred and seventy million perfectly complete buddhas, and I too now teach them and rejoice in them.

"Ānanda, if any faithful son of good family or daughter of good family holds, bears, reads, attends to, or masters these secret mantra bases of the great dhāraṇī, that person will remember former lives for up to seven lifetimes. That person will not turn back from the awakening mind.

"These, then, are the secret mantra bases of the great dhāraṇī:

tadyathā ante bandhe kṣame kṣamame dhānase badane adane hule mahāhule takare gaṃbhīre duṣpuste Protect me and all sentient beings from all fears, from harm, and from all contagious diseases, protect us, protect us! svāhā

"Ānanda, these secret mantra bases of the great dhāraṇī were spoken by eight hundred and eighty million perfectly complete buddhas, and I too now teach them and rejoice in them.

"Ānanda, if any faithful son of good family or daughter of good family bears, holds, reads, attends to, or masters these secret mantra bases of the great dhāraṇī, that person will remember former lives for up to fourteen lifetimes. That person will not turn back from the awakening mind.

"These, then, are the secret mantra bases of the great dhāraṇī:

tadyathā aṭṭe baṭṭe agge bagge ṭhagge ṭhagge dhakke dhāradhakke ṭakeṭarake akasi sakasi makasi ilimili tilimili raurabe mahāraurabe bhūtaṃgamebhūtaparāyaṇe timigise mahātimigese saṃbhābe mahāsaṃbhābe Protect me and all sentient beings from all fears, from all harm, and from all contagious diseases, protect us, protect us! svāhā

"Ānanda, these secret mantra bases of the great dhāraṇī were spoken by nine hundred and ninety million perfectly complete buddhas, and I too now teach them and rejoice in them.

"Ānanda, any faithful son of good family or daughter of good family who teaches, holds, reads, attends to, and masters these secret mantra bases of the great dhāraṇī will remember former lives for up to twenty-one lifetimes. That person will not turn back from the awakening mind.

"These, then, are the secret mantra bases of the great dhāraṇī:

tadyathā rule mahārule heheri mattari jaṃbhani staṃbhani

"Ānanda, suppose any faithful son of good family or daughter of good family, by means of these secret mantra bases of the great dhāraṇī, were to perform for a withered tree protection, or safeguarding, holding, and sustaining, pacification, the bringing of well-being, the averting of punishment, the averting of weapons, the neutralizing of poison, the destroying of poison, the sealing of boundaries, the binding of the sky and the binding of the ground, and were then to tie a thread around it. Its roots would grow again, and its branches, leaves, shoots, flowers and fruits would grow as well. What need, then, to speak of a body endowed with consciousness? Ānanda, the ripening of former karma alone is excepted."

"Ānanda, it is possible that these two, the sun and moon, renowned as so greatly miraculous, so greatly mighty and so greatly powerful, might fall to the ground. Ānanda, it is possible that Mount Meru, king of mountains, might move from its place. Ānanda, it is possible that these four great oceans, so deep, so vast, so greatly miraculous and so mighty, might dry up, be wholly exhausted, and come to an end. Ānanda, it is possible that this great earth might split into

a thousand pieces. It is possible that water might lose its very wetness. It is possible that fire might lose its heat. It is possible that wind might lose its coldness. But these foundations of the secret mantra of the great dhāraṇī cannot possibly fail.

"Ānanda, suppose a god, a nāga, an asura, a garuḍa, Vāyu, a gandharva, a kinnara, a mahoraga, a yakṣa, a rākṣasa, a preta, a piśāca, a kumbhāṇḍa, a pūtana, a kaṭapūtana, a bhūta, a brahmin, a rākṣasa, a shadow-oppressor, any human or nonhuman being whatsoever, or anyone else at all, transgresses these foundations of the secret mantra of the great dhāraṇī:

tadyathā aggile caggile balle malle ohāni mohāni jaṃbhani staṃbhani protect, protect me and all sentient beings, svāhā!

"Then the Great King Dhṛtarāṣṭra, with an iron wheel blazing, fiercely blazing, spreading everywhere and blazing, become a single mass of flame, will split his head into seven pieces. The Great Kings Virūḍhaka, Virūpākṣa and Vaiśravaṇa, too, with an iron wheel blazing, fiercely blazing, spreading everywhere and blazing, become a single mass of flame, will split his head into seven pieces. Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, will hurl his vajra. Vajrapāṇi, the Lord of Secrets, too, with a vajra blazing, fiercely blazing, spreading everywhere and blazing, become a single mass of flame, will split his head into seven pieces. He will have no power to remain in the royal palace of Aḍakavatī, and his head will split into seven pieces like a cluster of arjaka blossoms."

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the venerable Ānanda and the world with its gods, humans, asuras and gandharvas rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

This completes The Noble Great Dhāraṇī.

It was translated and edited by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Dānaśīla and the chief editor and translator, Bandé Yeshé Dé, and it was then revised and finalized according to the new terminology.

Translator's Notes

• Several items in the list of harmful beings are uncertain as class names. "Oppressing spirits," "shadow-seizing spirits," "slayers" and "harm-doers" render the Tibetan descriptively, because their Sanskrit equivalents cannot be identified with confidence. The identifications pūtana, kaṭapūtana, apasmāra and unmāda follow the usual Tibetan equivalents. "Sorcery" renders a term that can also mean a curse or hostile magic. The city given in Tibetan as "With Dwellings"

is taken as the usual rendering of Sāketa.
• The class of being called "shadow-oppressor" renders the Tibetan literally. A Sanskrit equivalent such as chāyāgraha is plausible, but it cannot be identified with confidence. The royal palace "lcang lo can" is taken as Aḍakavatī, the city of Vaiśravaṇa. The rākṣasa appears twice in the list, and both are kept as the text has them.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.